

Question: You are a historian of India in the year 2500CE. How would you reconstruct everyday life in early 21st century India? What sources would you use, what problems would you face, and how would you distinguish between reliable and misleading evidence?

What a good answer should contain

1. Identification of everyday life as not directly visible; need for reconstruction from traces
2. Range of sources (digital, state, material, visual, personal)
3. Problems of sources: bias, absence, over/under-representation
4. Method: source criticism, corroboration, and inference (Carr + Holmes)
5. Distinction between reliable and misleading evidence (context, cross-checking)

What it should NOT contain: Only listing sources, treating sources as evidence without critique, describing present-day life without historical method, totally ignoring both Carr and Holmes

Core evaluation criteria: Does the student show how historians *move from incomplete sources to reasoned interpretation*?